



Champions once again: City had to wait till the final day to seal the title after beating West Ham 3-2. **RIGHT, BELOW:** An ecstatic Pep Guardiola celebrates with Phil Foden, who was declared Player of the Season. PICS: AP

scored, 24 more than the previous tally set in 1992-93.

If there is one word to describe Manchester City since Pep Guardiola's arrival in 2016, it would be 'inevitable'. Even as Mikel Arteta's Arsenal set the club's season record of 28 wins, City beat the London side by two points.

Coming off a historic treble-winning campaign, City began its title defence with six wins in six, before succumbing to consecutive

defeats against Wolves and Arsenal. It then dropped 11 points out of a possible 18 in November-December and tumbled to fourth place by Christmas.

What followed was a phenomenon that football fans have become accustomed to, as City went on a 23-game unbeaten streak to retain the crown.

Meanwhile, Arsenal's chances took a hit when it lost to West Ham and Fulham in three days midway through the season. The final nail in the coffin was hammered by Aston Villa, which beat the Gunners 2-0 at the Emirates in April.

Fabulous Foden

The departure of captain Ilkay Gundogan and an injury to midfield maestro Kevin De Bruyne in the season opener brought the spotlight on local hero Phil Foden. The English youngster took the opportunity on the chin and recorded his career-best goals (19) and assists (8) tally, eventually winning the Premier League Player of the Season award.

Erling Haaland once again proved to be a menace for the opposition in front of goal, netting 27 goals and securing his second successive Golden Boot in what pundits considered a 'disappointing' campaign for the Norwegian.

Not a fairytale ending for Klopp

There was a point in the season when Liverpool was in contention to secure a quadruple, which would have made it a magical conclusion to a monumental nine-year reign by Jurgen Klopp (**above**) at the Merseyside club.

However, after his bombshell announcement in late January that he was stepping down as Liverpool manager, the team won the League Cup before crashing out of the FA Cup against Manchester United and the Europa League against Atalanta.

Liverpool kept pace with Man City and Arsenal at the top of the league table until its shocking defeats to Crystal Palace and city-rival Everton. Klopp's hope for a final title eventually subsided as it settled for third place.

